A Subway Ride Turns Into a Comedy Show

From: CBC World Mined: 2026-10-27 3 min read

It is not every day that running **errands** turns into a comedy show on the New York City subway. But that is what happened to Debbie Shields, a Brooklyn bar owner who runs a comedy night.

Shields was on her way to see her **accountant** when she started talking with comedian Conan O'Brien. She had no idea what she was walking into, but she was ready. 'If you give it to me, I give it right back to you,' she later said.

O'Brien was a guest on SubwayTakes, a popular internet talk show hosted by comedian Kareem Rahma. Near the end of the **episode**, O'Brien joked that he and Shields used to be married. Shields fired back at once: they had two kids. 'One's in medical school, the other one's in jail,' she said, and O'Brien cracked up.

O'Brien told New York Magazine he would love to work with Shields again. Since the **episode** aired, she has become an internet **sensation**, with calls coming in from Japan, Australia and England.

Word Treasure

accountant -- A person whose job is to keep track of money and money records.

sensation -- Someone or something that suddenly becomes very famous and talked about a lot.

errands -- Small jobs or trips you do, like shopping or going to an appointment.

episode -- One single show in a series of shows.

Background you need

The New York City subway is an underground train system that carries people around the city.

SubwayTakes is a popular internet talk show filmed on the subway.

A comedy night is an evening event where comedians perform jokes for an audience.

Break it down

WHO: Debbie Shields, Conan O'Brien, and Kareem Rahma.
WHAT: Shields talked with O'Brien on a SubwayTakes episode, and their quick jokes made her famous online.
WHERE: The New York City subway, and Shields is from Brooklyn.
WHY: O'Brien was filming a SubwayTakes episode on the subway, and Shields answered his jokes right back.

Why it matters

It shows that being ready to speak up and be yourself can turn an ordinary day into something special.

Test what you remember

1. Who is Debbie Shields?

(A) The host of SubwayTakes
(B) A comedian guest on SubwayTakes
(C) An accountant
(D) A Brooklyn bar owner who runs a comedy night

2. Where was Shields going when she met O'Brien?

(A) To a comedy night
(B) To Japan
(C) To work with O'Brien
(D) To see her accountant

3. What show was O'Brien a guest on?

(A) SubwayTakes
(B) A Brooklyn bar
(C) A medical school
(D) New York Magazine

4. What did O'Brien joke near the end of the episode?

(A) That Shields runs a bar
(B) That one's in medical school
(C) That he and Shields used to be married
(D) That he was an accountant

5. What did Shields say about the two kids?

(A) Both are in medical school
(B) One's in Japan
(C) Both are in jail
(D) One's in medical school, the other one's in jail

6. What happened since the episode aired?

(A) She moved to Japan
(B) She stopped running her comedy night
(C) She became an internet sensation, with calls coming in from Japan, Australia and England
(D) She married O'Brien

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: A 4: C 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):